

everything he does. In fact, an exactly average human would have to be half male and half female. Quételet completely missed that point.

God's Error

A much more worrisome aspect of the discussion is that in Quételet's day, the name of the Gaussian distribution was *la loi des erreurs*, the law of errors, since one of its earliest applications was the distribution of errors in astronomic measurements. Are you as worried as I am? Divergence from the mean (here the median as well) was treated precisely as an error! No wonder Marx fell for Quételet's ideas.

This concept took off very quickly. The *ought* was confused with the *is*, and this with the imprimatur of science. The notion of the average man is steeped in the culture attending the birth of the European middle class, the nascent post-Napoleonic shopkeeper's culture, chary of excessive wealth and intellectual brilliance. In fact, the dream of a society with compressed outcomes is assumed to correspond to the aspirations of a rational human being facing a genetic lottery. If you had to pick a society to be born into for your next life, but could not know which outcome awaited you, it is assumed you would probably take no gamble; you would like to belong to a society without divergent outcomes.

One entertaining effect of the glorification of mediocrity was the creation of a political party in France called Poujadism, composed initially of a grocery-store movement. It was the warm huddling together of the semi-favored hoping to see the rest of the universe compress itself into their rank—a case of non-proletarian revolution. It had a grocery-store-owner mentality, down to the employment of the mathematical tools. Did Gauss provide the mathematics for the shopkeepers?

Poincaré to the Rescue

Poincaré himself was quite suspicious of the Gaussian. I suspect that he felt queasy when it and similar approaches to modeling uncertainty were presented to him. Just consider that the Gaussian was initially meant to measure astronomic errors, and that Poincaré's ideas of modeling celestial mechanics were fraught with a sense of deeper uncertainty.

Poincaré wrote that one of his friends, an unnamed "eminent physicist," complained to him that physicists tended to use the Gaussian curve because they thought mathematicians believed it a mathematical necessity; mathematicians used it because they believed that physicists found it to be an